



HOME AWAY FROM HOME:

A Targeted Approach to Host Family
Recruitment for AFS MOGY



<https://bit.ly/4cw84lR>

Student Support Squad

Please contact Tyra Le at (314) 600-1858
or l.tyra@wustl.edu with any questions.

Table of Contents

Executive Summary: Reimagining Host Family Recruitment for AFS.....	4
Introduction	4
Audience	4
Strategy	4
Solution 1: Soccer Tournament Outreach	4
Solution 2: Handwritten Letters	5
Solution 3:	5
Introduction	6
Problem	6
Methodology	6
Agenda	6
Audience Analysis	7
Meet The Smiths.....	7
Demographics.....	7
Psychographics.....	7
Motivators.....	7
Deterrents.....	8
Context.....	9
Industry	9
Overview	9
Industry Conditions	9
Area.....	10
St. Louis City has many attractions that can foster foreign student exchange	10
Economy.....	10
St. Louis' economy is growing, which makes it easier for households to add a resident.....	10
Current Trends	10
Recruiting host families has been increasingly more challenging	10
The “ideal host family” image is evolving.....	11
Heightened feelings of loneliness and isolation.....	11
Growing “values-based” motivation for families.....	11
Competitor Analysis	11

Overview	11
Communications.....	12
Conclusions.....	13
Statement of Purpose.....	14
Statement of Problem.....	14
Agenda	14
Communication Strategy	15
Phase 1: Identifying Strategic Soccer Tournaments for Outreach	15
Why Soccer Tournaments?	15
Event Selection	15
Phase 2: Reinforce and Persuade – Handwritten Letters	16
Phase 3: Closing the Deal – Phone Calls	18
Impact	20
Slide Deck.....	21
Bibliography	25

Executive Summary: Reimagining Host Family Recruitment for AFS

Introduction

AFS Intercultural Programs has a distinguished legacy as a global nonprofit committed to fostering intercultural understanding through student exchange. However, the landscape for host families — particularly in the St. Louis region — has changed significantly. AFS-MOGY (St. Louis) now operates within a more competitive environment shaped by shifting family demographics, generational changes, and an increase in recruiting competition host families within St. Louis.

Audience

92% of international exchange student organizations struggle with host family recruitment (Study Travel Network 2023). Key challenges include the rising cost of living, busier family schedules that limit the flexibility to welcome another person into their home, and host families being unable to connect with their exchange student. Simultaneously, policies under the new administration create uncertainty for host families and students. These policies have focused on student visa revocations and detentions, which can cause confusion in potential host families' minds about hosting. Despite challenges organizations have expressed and new policies that are being administered, families want their children to connect with the world. Per the Survey Center of American Life in 2023, 49% of families prioritize global exposure for their children, which directly aligns with AFS's goal of raising global active host families and exchange students.

In St. Louis, there are numerous student exchange organizations that are actively recruiting host families within St. Louis and new policies that pose difficulty. However, AFS has built its reputation on culture rooted in cultural diplomacy, with their goal of instilling global awareness directly aligns with families seeking global exposure for their children.

Therefore, this is the perfect opportunity for AFS to leverage its unique culture and core strengths to recruit 10-15 additional host families for their Missouri Gateway branch.

Strategy

AFS-MOGY has found past success with matching potential host families and prospective exchange students using extracurricular activity involvement. By matching certain interests such as being soccer fans, artists, and or musicians, AFS can ensure that a successful match is made. Based on this reasoning, we decided to focus on families with children involved in soccer, ensuring that there can be a point of similarity between host families and exchange students.

Solution 1: Soccer Tournament Outreach

AFS MOGY will begin by identifying a couple local youth soccer tournaments, such as the LFA Midwest Spring Invitational and the Missouri Rush Mother's Day Classic, where families already gather around values of community, teamwork, and youth development.

- **Soccer Tournament Outreach from AFS:** At these events, AFS will provide tournament organizers and coaches with flyers and information they can use to introduce the hosting opportunity to families. These materials will include QR codes for sign-up or more Information and invite parents to connect further with AFS at future phases of the communication strategy.

This solution is highly targeted, low-cost, and simple for volunteers to execute, making the phase feasible and strong for AFS.

Solution 2: Handwritten Letters

Our second solution aims to go from information giving to action by having current AFS students write handwritten letters to potential host families at AFS tabling.

- **Handwritten Letters from Current Exchange Students to Potential Host Families:** Handing out handwritten letters at AFS tabling during soccer tournaments conveys care and attention. Potential AFS families create an emotional connection during tabling, making the interaction more memorable.

We propose having current AFS students send handwritten letters to families who visit the AFS tabling at soccer tournaments. These letters will include a personal story and a thank you to these potential host families. Phrases like “thank you” or “changing lives” can emphasize the impact these families could have, motivating them to continue in the hosting process.

Solution 3:

After potential host families have been introduced to AFS MOGY through various channels, our third solution focuses on finalizing their commitment through a personal connection.

- **One-on-one phone calls from volunteers to potential host families:** Contacting potential host families who have demonstrated high interest thus far—in one-on-one phone calls—conveys care and attention. This call maximizes the probability of getting each host family to join AFS.

We propose having volunteers reach out to different families over the phone to give gratitude, reiterate their importance, and answer any questions needed for AFS. By reaching out over the phone, AFS is showing personalized care for each prospective family. It’s important to demonstrate these values during our process to continuously reinforce AFS’s message of connectivity.

PAC Report

Introduction

American Field Services – Missouri Gateway’s (AFS MOGY) key goal is to increase the number of host families for their study abroad program, specifically in the greater Missouri area and Western Illinois. AFS MOGY was able to host around fifty students per year before the COVID-19 pandemic. AFS MOGY has been struggling to reach their previous numbers following the pandemic. Our solution aims to help AFS MOGY target potential host families and increase the number of host families in their Missouri Gateway branch. Our solution also aims to recommend actionable recruitment strategies based on achievability, audience insights, and local outreach opportunities.

Problem

AFS MOGY is looking for a way to recruit host families in their Missouri Gateway branch. They have found success following COVID-19, with around thirty students studying abroad in Missouri and Western Illinois. While AFS MOGY’s program is gaining traction, there remains a discrepancy between pre-pandemic and current numbers. Hosting an international exchange student through AFS MOGY’s programs allows families to experience and share a new culture firsthand. Specifically, AFS MOGY aims to recruit fifteen more host families by June 1, 2025. Meeting this target will allow AFS MOGY to scale back to its previous program capacity and enable students to study abroad in the Missouri region.

Methodology

The research from this report came from several sources. Some of these include:

- Academic sources: Peer-reviewed studies on host family motivations and the benefits of cultural exchange in the region
- Government data: Demographic and income statistics from sources like the CDC and U.S. Census Bureau
- Internal organizational insights: Information from AFS MOGY’s internal recruitment efforts and prior engagement tactics
- Local sports and community organizations: SYLSA

Agenda

We address how AFS MOGY can take advantage of its opportunity to increase the number of host families. This report first provides an example of AFS MOGY’s ideal host family, then analyzes their traits, motivations, and deterrents. Next, the report analyzes AFS MOGY’s respective industry and relevant trends they must consider. Finally, this report concludes with takeaways and implications for AFS MOGY’s strategic communications.

Audience Analysis

Meet The Smiths

The Smiths serve as a sample character from our target demographic of host families with children in soccer leagues. Based on their background, lifestyle, and experiences, they would be the best fit for achieving AFS MOGY's goals. They are currently a family of four, consisting of Mr. and Mrs. Smith (aged thirty-five) and Sarah and Timmy (aged fourteen and twelve, respectively). The family of four is highly interested in soccer: both children participate in soccer leagues. With an income of about \$215,000 annually, they are a financially stable family in the St. Louis suburban area. They are looking to learn more about what it means to be a host family for AFS MOGY while also deciding if it is something they wish to do.



(Getty Images 2025)

Demographics

Our target audience consists of parents between the ages of thirty and fifty who have children in school and participate in soccer leagues. These families typically have an income level of four times the Federal Poverty Level (FPL). These findings align with data from the CDC, which indicates that 70.2% of children involved in sports come from households earning 400% of the FPL (CDC 2022). They are primarily located in the St. Louis metro area, including Western Illinois and the surrounding suburban regions. The family structure includes two- and single-parent households with at least one child engaged in a soccer league. This demographic is well-suited for fostering a stronger connection between AFS students and host families, as a shared activity like soccer can enhance overall experiences and their bond.

Psychographics

Families with children in soccer leagues lead an active lifestyle, prioritizing involvement in extracurricular activities and fostering collaboration within the family. They value inclusivity and philanthropy, aligning with AFS's culture of volunteering without monetary incentives. These parents are committed to personal development and seeking opportunities to expose their children to global experiences. Socially, they are engaged in St. Louis and Western Illinois youth soccer organizations, further reinforcing their community involvement and dedication to their children's growth through sports and cultural exchange.

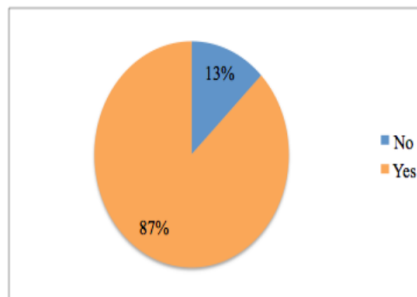
Motivators

AFS' potential host families are motivated by several aspects.

- Exchange of cultures: The opportunity for the family to understand another culture and share their family traditions with an AFS student.

- Educational advantage: Children of host families will gain unique experiences to leverage in interviews/classes to stand out from peers.
- Community engagement: This aligns with charitable values and gives back to the St. Louis community by encouraging diversity in soccer organizations and schools.
- Extracurricular involvement: Having an AFS student could encourage the children of a host family to explore other extracurriculars or enhance existing skills.

In a survey conducted by HostFamilies.org, many host families reported positive experiences, and a significant portion stated that they would host again (Host Family Survey Results 2016).



(Host Family Survey Results 2016)

Deterrents

A few reasons could discourage families from participating in the AFS host program.

- Housing issues: Families may worry about housing space or room accommodations.
- Financial concerns: Families with fewer resources or more expenses may be concerned about the costs of having another child. These could include extra food, transportation, activities, and social obligations.
- Family dynamics: Some parents may be concerned that an additional child may affect their current children. Parents may fear jealousy, lack of attention, or resentment could arise from adding another child.

Time commitments: Families may fear that taking care of another child will add stress to their schedules, causing them to feel stressed and overwhelmed.

In addition, the Iceberg Model illustrates both surface level and underlying factors that influence host families (Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs 2024). AFS should address financial and space concerns, acknowledge changing family dynamics, and offer future support.

Context

Industry

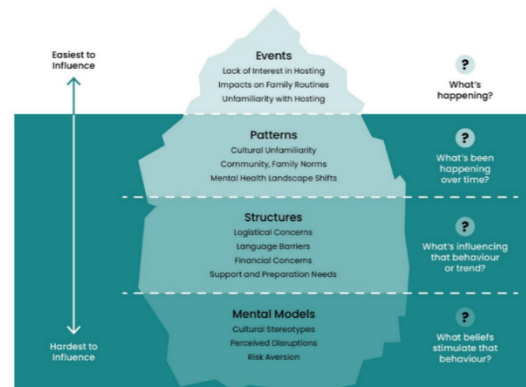
Overview

AFS MOGY finds itself in the foreign exchange student industry. They have a unique stance as the only wholly volunteer-based program, making operations more difficult but very socially enhancing. These organizations aim to match as many international students as possible with host families.

Industry Conditions

Unfortunately, most organizations in the foreign exchange industry have been facing tougher industry conditions, as student visas have not retraced the 2015 peak. Therefore, each organization must capitalize on interested students and have a high success rate of matching them with a host family.

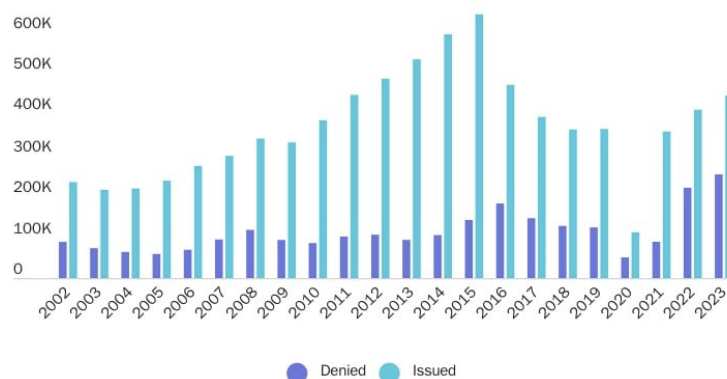
The Iceberg Model: More than Meets the Eye to Hosting Exchange Students



(Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs 2024)

Student visa refusals peaked in 2023 while student visa issuances have not recovered

Student visas refused and issued, FY 2002–2023



(NASH 2024)

Since 2016, net acceptances in student visas have dropped significantly. While acceptances have risen since 2020, visa denials have simultaneously risen, revealing adverse industry conditions. Aside from the current state of visas, the foreign exchange industry is already quite competitive as AFS has over 10 nearby competitors. Getting international students to the U.S. is

niche and specialized, giving the students more power in the exchange program market. These conditions make it hard for organizations to enter and compete.

Area

St. Louis's dynamic is important for AFS' success in the region. Most importantly, St. Louis's large suburban presence is crucial to MOGY-specific operations.

St. Louis County's population has been stable over time due to nearby counties growing, while the city's population has declined over the same time interval (Norman 2024). Strong suburban growth across many counties is crucial because exchange programs are most common in these areas. Since finding hosts is challenging, maintaining the most potential families is critical.

Area	1970 Population	2022 Population	Percentage Change
St. Louis MSA	622236	990414	59.19%
City of St. Louis	951671	286578	-69.89%
St. Charles County	92954	413803	345.17%
Jefferson County	105248	229336	117.90%
Franklin County	55127	105879	92.06%

(Nash 2024)

St. Louis City has many attractions that can foster foreign student exchange

The city of St. Louis has a variety of entertainment attractions. A prospective exchange student wants a fantastic experience when visiting the United States. St. Louis is great at maintaining a welcoming culture with its attractions, with a variety of different activities that can reach different types of students. For instance, students who like sports have the St. Louis Cardinals, Blues, and Soccer Club. Those interested in the arts and history have the City Museum, St. Louis Science Center, and St. Louis Art Museum.

Economy

St. Louis' economic state has directly impacted AFS MOGY's housing availability, and the COVID-19 pandemic has been difficult to recover from. Many factors, including housing costs, price index, and financial stress, disrupted AFS' supply chain. This caused a massive dent in their volunteer force, which they are still working to rebuild.

St. Louis' economy is growing, which makes it easier for households to add a resident

St. Louis has seen favorable economic metrics recently, including a GDP increase of 2.5% and a personal income increase of 33% per capita (Wyche 2024). This positively impacts AFS in two ways. First, the city's increasing GDP signals strong business trends, indicating a positive location to live in. On the other hand, increasing personal income improves families' confidence in their ability to host another student, which is one of the most crucial factors in choosing to be a host family.

Current Trends

In the short term, host family recruitment faces some challenges:

Recruiting host families has been increasingly more challenging

A Council on Standards for International Educational Travel members survey states that 92% of American F-1 and J-1 organizations expressed recent difficulty in host family recruitment (Study Travel Network 2023). Key challenges identified include (i) the rising cost of living (81%), (ii) behavior and adaptability concerns centered around the mobile phone usage of students and

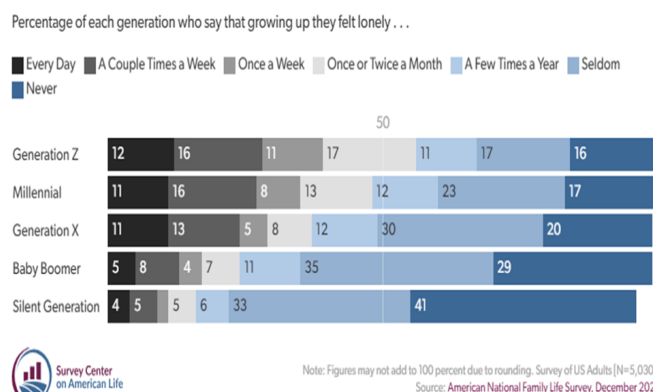
the negative impact on connecting with host families (42%), and (iii) busier family schedules limiting the flexibility to welcome another person into the home (38%).

The “ideal host family” image is evolving

Only 46% of children lived with two parents in their first marriage in 2015, down from 73% in 1960 (Pew Research Center 2015). This indicates a substantial decline in what is traditionally considered the “nuclear family.” The same report highlighted that 26% of children lived with a single parent and 7% with cohabiting parents, reflecting the diversification of family arrangements.

Historically, recruitment materials may have targeted nuclear families, but this narrow definition of “family” can limit reach. Single parents, empty nesters, blended families, and child-free couples must be actively welcomed and included. Messaging should emphasize that any stable, supportive home, not just those with children, can host.

Heightened feelings of loneliness and isolation



56% of Gen Z felt lonely during childhood, compared to 24% of Boomers (American National Family Life Survey 2021).

Loneliness and isolation are a part of modern American life — especially for younger generations who may now be raising families themselves. Hosting an exchange student can be a mutually beneficial solution for host families to

establish an emotional connection and feel a sense of purpose and companionship. Gen-Z and Millennials may see hosting to build community and model meaningful relationships for their children.

Growing “values-based” motivation for families

49% of American families say intercultural exposure is a priority for their children (Survey Center of American Life, 2023). Hosting is a direct, personal way for families to engage with global culture, and AFS can frame it in a manner that teaches empathy, global citizenship, and tolerance. This highlights how hosting supports intercultural learning, empathy, and preparing children for a global world can resonate with modern parents.

Competitor Analysis

Overview

Several organizations in St. Louis are active in recruiting host families for international students. These organizations vary in terms of their structure (profit / non-profit) and hosting goals. The table below highlights the competitive landscape:

Organization	Visa (F-1/J-1)	Description
AFS Intercultural Programs	J-1	One of the oldest cultural exchange organizations promoting intercultural understanding and raising globally active citizens.
Educatus Group	F-1	Global education company with a strong focus on host family integration and education.
Youth For Understanding (YFU)	J-1	Global network focused on intercultural youth exchanges. Emphasizes personal growth and lifelong learning.
International Student Exchange (ISE)	J-1	Facilitates cultural exchange for high school students with a wide U.S network.
Council on International and Educational Exchange (CIEE)	J-1	Large cultural exchange nonprofit focused on supporting cultural diplomacy and providing educational opportunities. Host families choose to volunteer
International Cultural Exchange Services (ICES)	J-1	Offers international high school exchange with support services. Focus on cultural exchange. Host families choose to volunteer.
The Cambridge Network	F-1	Works primarily with private high schools in the U.S and China. The program places a focus on academic achievement
Aspect Foundation	J-1	Small-to-mid-sized exchange nonprofit focused on student immersion and cross-cultural learning. Hosts choose to volunteer.
STS Foundation	J-1	Recently acquired by Educatus Group, but still operates as a cultural exchange nonprofit, where host families choose to volunteer.
Greenheart Exchange	J-1	Offers cultural exchange, internships, and volunteer opportunities. Strong focus on community service and sustainability.

Communications

AFS MOGY primarily utilizes communication mediums such as word-of-mouth, school visits, a strong website, and Facebook. Their competitors also use similar mediums. For example, Youth for Understanding rely on word-of-mouth, social media (such as LinkedIn), and their website. With most of AFS MOGY's competitors using similar mediums, AFS MOGY must ensure that their communication mediums stand out, especially in such a highly competitive industry.

Conclusions

Overall, AFS MOGY has a clear goal: recruit 15 new host families by June 1, 2025, and return to the scale they maintained before the pandemic. This report lays out a focused strategy to achieve this goal, grounded in data, local insight, and a deep understanding of the kinds of families most likely to say yes.

We have identified a core target audience—active, community-driven families with school-aged kids, especially those involved in youth soccer. These families already prioritize extracurriculars, cultural exposure, and personal development. AFS MOGY must address fundamental concerns, from space and financial costs to shifting family dynamics to succeed. They must do all this while expanding the definition of a “host family” in 2025.

The path forward is actionable. Soon, AFS should:

- Double-down on partnerships with youth sports organizations to reach **engaged** families where they already are.
- Adjust messaging to highlight the **unique benefits** for kids in host families, like emotional connection and shared growth.
- **Broaden outreach** to include single parents, child-free couples, and others who many do not see themselves in traditional recruitment materials.
- Avoid using social and digital platforms to inform (e.g. current website) but to inspire. Telling stories that make hosting feel **meaningful, doable, and urgent** fosters real emotions and investment in foreign exchange students and hosting.

The opportunity is real. Exchange experiences are seeing a rebounding increase in demand, and families are craving new connections and purpose. With targeted outreach and the right message, AFS MOGY can exceed its goals, helping more students experience American life while strengthening communities across Missouri and Illinois.

Strategy Report

Statement of Purpose

This report is a continuation of the “Purpose, Audience, and Context” report. The purpose of this report is to provide a three-tiered communication strategy to solve AFS MOGY’s problem of finding host families for their student exchange program. This strategy report includes specific actions they should take and the media they should use. The report closes with the further impact that the solution will have for AFS MOGY.

Statement of Problem

AFS MOGY is looking for a way to recruit host families in their Missouri Gateway branch. While AFS MOGY’s program is gaining traction, there remains a discrepancy between pre-pandemic and current numbers. Specifically, AFS MOGY’s goal is to recruit fifteen more host families by June 1, 2025. Meeting this target will allow AFS MOGY to scale back to their previous program capacity and offer students the opportunity to study abroad in the region.

Agenda

This report provides a three-part solution designed to reach AFS MOGY’s target audience of families with children who are involved in soccer. The key elements of our strategy are:

- Email with Flyer: An Email from AFS to Tournament Leads; A Flyer from AFS to Soccer Families
- Handwritten Letters: From Current AFS Exchange Students to Potential Host Families
- Phone Call Guide: For AFS Volunteers to Use with Potential Host Families

The foundation for our solution is based on the PAC report, which provides an overview of AFS MOGY’s purpose, target audience, and relevant context. With this information, we found that families with children involved in soccer need:

1. A meaningful cultural exchange: Being able to learn more about a culture different from their own and being able to share their own culture as well.
2. Community engagement: These families heavily value giving back to the St. Louis community.
3. Extracurricular (soccer) involvement: These families find happiness and enjoyment from being involved in soccer programs and activities.

Communication Strategy

Phase 1: Identifying Strategic Soccer Tournaments for Outreach

Phase 1 of our strategy focuses on locating youth soccer tournaments in the St. Louis area where AFS can easily and effectively conduct outreach. There are many beneficial reasons for soccer tournaments, including meeting potential host families in environments aligned with their values: community, youth development, and international engagement. Through this medium, AFS can establish meaningful connections with strong prospects in a way that is **approachable and low-cost**. This phase lays the foundation for the tabling, flyering, and storytelling phases of the broader strategy.

Why Soccer Tournaments?

Soccer is the most international sport in the world. It is also one of the most popular youth sports in the United States, particularly regarding families that value teamwork and extracurricular involvement. These two characteristics are ones we've identified as strongly aligning with AFS MOGY's ideal host family profile. These are families that are frequently active in their communities, seeking meaningful enrichment experiences for their children, and willing to take on volunteer commitments if they resonate with their values.

Soccer tournaments offer an unusually strong opportunity to meet these families where they already are. Digital outreach works, but it involves competing for attention in an oversaturated environment. Whereas soccer tournaments provide a focused window to connect in person, when families are already thinking about international culture, youth development and team-based learning. Tournaments also offer predictability in scheduling and direct access to hundreds of relevant families across just a few weekends. For a smaller organization like AFS MOGY, these concentrated outreach moments are significantly more efficient than year-round cold outreach.

Event Selection

To simplify our implementation, we selected two smaller, yet high-traffic soccer tournaments hosted by reputable youth soccer organizations that attract local and regional families. These tournaments are manageable in size, logistically straightforward, and offer low-cost or no-cost tabling opportunities. They also occur within a short timeframe, which allows AFS to focus efforts and resources efficiently over the next six weeks.

The two recommended events are:

1. LFA Midwest Spring Invitational – April 25-27, 2025

Hosted at the Lou Fusz Soccer Complex, this tournament is run by Lou Fusz Athletic (LFA), one of the most established youth soccer clubs in the region. With teams from Missouri, Illinois, and surrounding states, the event attracts families who d

Below is a sample flyer that AFS MOGY could use:



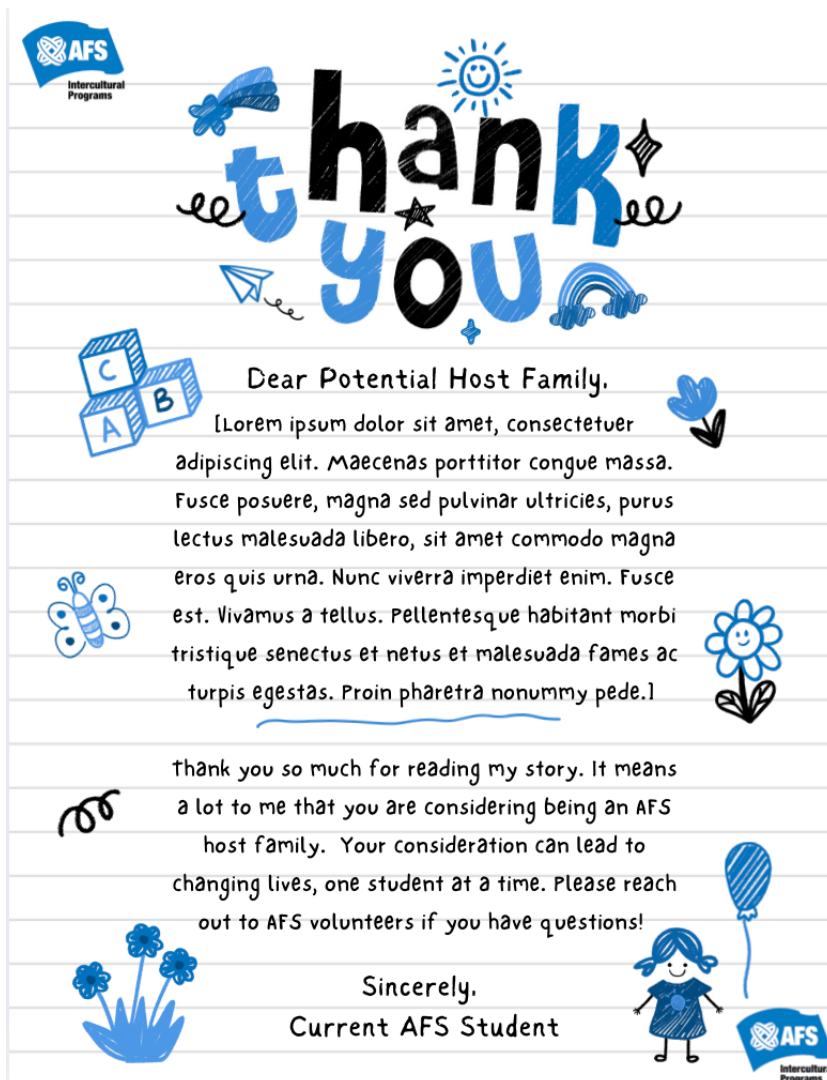
Phase 2: Reinforce and Persuade – Handwritten Letters

AFS MOGY should utilize handwritten letters from current exchange students to potential host families. These handwritten letters can be made at the soccer tournament tabling events as AFS volunteers and students will be present. The letters are also flexible in nature; Letters can be premade and printed so that students have the letters available at tabling. The letters would then be handed to potential host families that visit the table, reaching the target audience with an emotional exchange from a current AFS student. Three templates can be provided for students, making writing and completion efficient. These templates include three writing points:

- Personal stories from
- Cross-cultural soccer connections

- Stories of making a difference

Below is a sample letter that AFS MOGY could use at their tabling events:



Phase 2 will be successful for numerous reasons:

- Handwritten letters have been proven to illustrate care and attentiveness (Bundyra, 2025).
 - This means that handwritten letters have a strong emotional appeal, making them a strong medium.
 - It's important to reach soccer families with this emotional appeal, as it relates to their motivators (e.g. giving back to the community).
- Moreover, if AFS MOGY and Syd already have examples of these prompts, lettering can be streamlined accordingly.
- Handwritten letters can also fulfill AFS exchange students' volunteer hours requirement – serving as a multi-purpose medium.

- For the tabling aspect, tabling is a medium that AFS MOGY is familiar with, demonstrating its ease-of-use.
 - Tabling is familiar, making the medium comfortable.

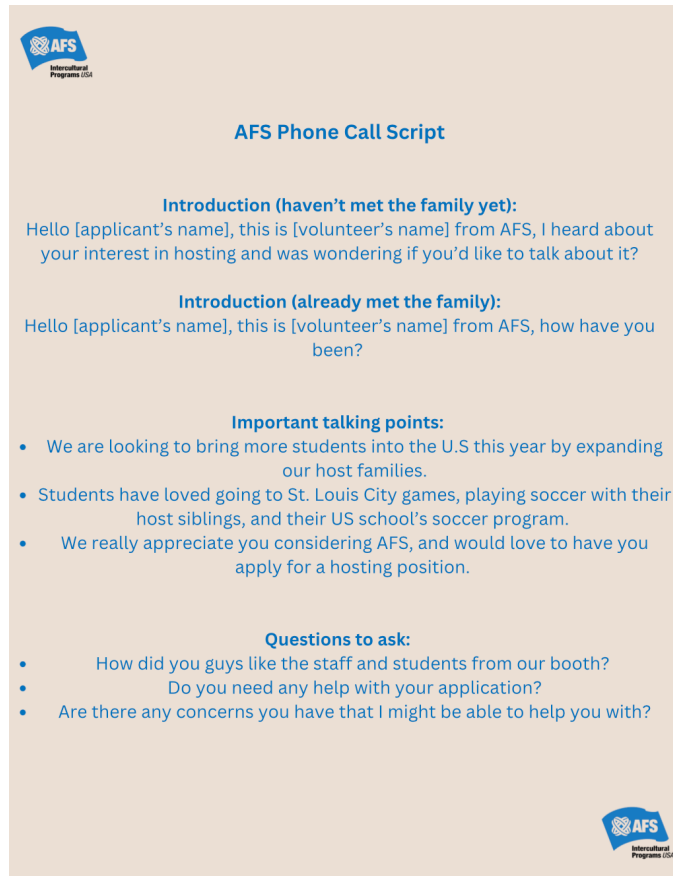
Phase 3: Closing the Deal – Phone Calls

After AFS continues to generate interested families through Phases 1 and 2, they should utilize a 1-on-1 phone call with those who've shown abundant interest. In this channel, the most promising host applicants will receive a call from an AFS volunteer. AFS will navigate the applicants who received a personalized letter and follow up with them over the phone.

AFS volunteers must follow a strategic guideline to have the highest probability of closing the deal:

- Express gratitude to the host families for considering AFS: Families that don't receive follow-ups from AFS may think that AFS doesn't support their program's operations as much as competitors. It is a strong and respectful message to express how AFS appreciates their host families.
- Reinforce how AFS values the family and what the family can do for the students: This point will make host families feel positive about what they can do to help AFS's operation. AFS should stress at this point in the phone call how much the students enjoy what the program does, events and tangible factors that demonstrate the success of AFS, and list positive experiences that host families have. They can lean into how soccer can bring them together, while also stressing the strong cultural connection that AFS consolidates.
- Offer help with the application and any questions that they might have about AFS: This section of the call should be completely host driven. Any of their needs or questions that they have about any AFS related information should be answered. If the volunteer needs help with a question, they can follow up with the potential host. This part of the conversation is the most important because any questions, worries, and concerns the host family may have need to be answered. This is to avoid them potentially moving on without proper closure, which would be significantly inefficient for AFS and the family.

Below is a sample script that AFS MOGY could use during their 1-on-1 phone calls:



This phase outline is important because:

- Voice conversations are more personal than text or digital messages (Tanzanko 2024). There are many reasons why people prefer voice messages for different tasks than others. One of the most important for this phase is the connection that voice messages bring that digital messaging can't. A Stanford University study even "found that participants felt more connected and engaged when using voice communication compared to text-based interactions" (Tanzanko 2024). This will help continue our strategic goal of connecting personally with other families to expand the mission of AFS.
- Host families must decide soon on whether they are hosting a student, so last minute positive reinforcements can help: For the host families that haven't fully committed to AFS, this can serve as a last push to try and flip them. By utilizing the guidelines for this step, AFS volunteers are maximizing the probability of each host joining the program.

To implement this strategy, AFS must:

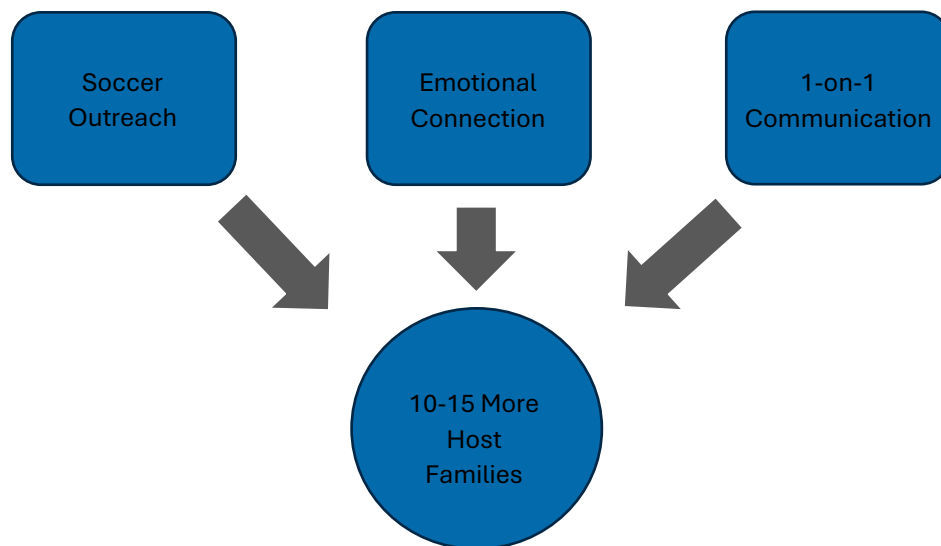
1. List every host family that attended the AFS booth: Volunteers must list a contact method for each family along with a paired volunteer to call them-if the volunteer has

met the family, they should be paired with them, creating the strongest connection possible.

2. Briefly prep each volunteer with the script and key points: Host one call/meeting with all the volunteers who are outreaching to quickly prepare and answer any of the volunteer questions regarding this process.
3. Have each volunteer record how the call went and document the family's level of interest and specific thoughts about joining AFS. This will help AFS understand who's on the fence and provide a good estimate of how many families AFS will get.

Impact

Our three-tiered communication strategy will have the following impact for AFS MOGY:



Relevant Costs for our Strategy Include:

- Flyers (~\$890 for 500)
- Lettering (~\$35-40 for 150)
 - Paper
 - Markers
 - Potential Printing Costs

This communication strategy is very feasible for AFS MOGY, and it will add incredible value in terms of host family recruitment. The value includes initial awareness through coach outreach, emotional connections with handwritten lettering, and finally a call to action with 1-on-1 phone calls. The value is not limited to AFS alone—potential host families gain value through diverse cultural experiences and philanthropy, while current AFS students aid in giving back to AFS. All-in-all, our strategy provides a mutually beneficial relationship for all parties involved while being feasible for AFS MOGY.



Home Away From Home

By Student Support Squad

"We are the world, we are the children, we are the ones who make a brighter day, so let's start giving"

- Michael Jackson and Lionel Richie



Agenda

- 01 Context and Target Audience
- 02 Strategy
- 03 Implications
- 04 Call to Action

01 What Context Does AFS Need and Who is Our Target Audience?

Context

- 92% of international exchange student organizations struggle with host family recruitment (Study Travel Network 2023)
- Policies under new administration
 - Visa revocations and detentions
- 49% of families prioritize global exposure for their children (Survey Center of American Life 2023)



Acting with Urgency

- Shrinking pool of host families
- Increased competition
- AFS's mission aligns with current trends in global exposure

Purpose

- Number of host families decreased from 50 to 29 ~42% since 2020
- Recruit 10-15 additional host families

Who is the audience?

Families Participating in Soccer Programs

- **Demographics**
 - Ages 30-50, 4x poverty level (70% of children in sports), children in soccer leagues (CDC)
- **Motivations**
 - Exchange of cultures
 - Educational advantage
 - Community/extracurricular involvement
- **Deterrents**
 - Housing, financial, time concerns
 - Family dynamics
- **Values**
 - Philanthropy, inclusivity, exposure for children to global experiences

Audience Profile

Meet the Smiths

- Family of 4
- Parents ages 35
- Income of \$215,000
- St. Louis suburbs
- Children Sarah and Timmy play soccer
- Prioritize education and new experiences



(Getty Images 2025)

AFS-MOGY's Key Message

AFS MOGY offers an emotionally rich and culturally expansive program that connects your family to the world—through the universal language of soccer. By hosting an international exchange student, you'll not only open your home to global friendship, but also share in the passion for the world's most popular sport. Soccer and AFS MOGY bring people together across borders, creating lasting unforgettable memories. Start your rewarding journey today—host with AFS MOGY!

02 & 03

What Strategy Should AFS-MOGY Use & What Are the Implications?

HOST A STUDENT. CHANGE A LIFE.

Make a lifelong impact
Learn about another culture
Fully supported by AFS



Scan to
Learn More



AFS AT YOUR LOCAL
SOCCER TOURNAMENT
LEARN MORE OR CONTACT US
info@afs.org • www.afs.org
(123) 456-7890



Targeted Local Orgs

Starting with Lou Fusz Athletic Midwest
Spring Invitational
April 25-27, 2025

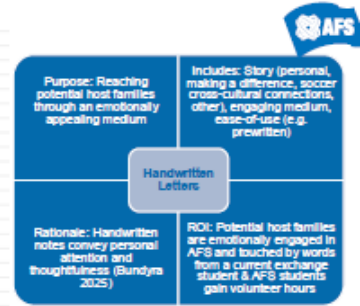
Missouri Rush Mother's Day Classic
May 9-11, 2025

High traffic youth sports communities

The cost to value ratio for the flyers is low.

- Relevant Costs Include:**
- ~\$890 total for 500 flyers

- The Value Includes:**
- 90%+ open/read rate
 - Builds trust & emotional connection
 - Higher engagement than just digital outreach

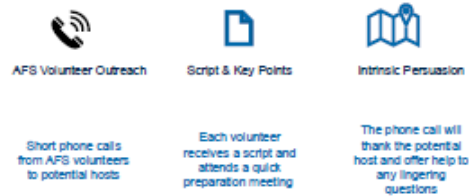


The cost to value ratio for handwritten letters is low.

- Relevant Costs Include:**
- Paper: Wide Ruled Loose Leaf: \$0.97/Pack of 150
 - Markers: \$3.97/10 Pack of Crayola Washable Markers
 - Printing Costs: \$30 for Colored Sheets
 - Total: 150 letters for \$35.50

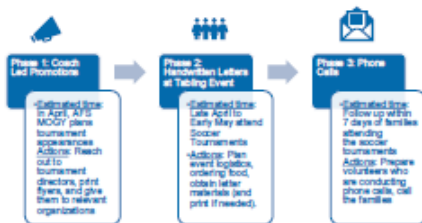
- The Value Includes:**
- Strengthening emotional connection
 - Direct messaging from a current exchange student

Phase 3: One-On-One Phone Calls with Potential Host Families



04 What Are The Next Steps?

AFS-MOGY Should Use This Timeline



Executive Summary



Audience

- Families with Children Involved in Soccer Programs



Strategy

- Targeting Local Soccer Tournaments Through Email and Flyers
- Handwritten Letters At Soccer Tournament Tabling
- Phone Call Guides During 1-on-1 Phone Calls

References

- Bradley, Katie. 2020. "The Value of a Handwritten Note." *Princeton*. <https://www.princeton.com/article/notes-handwritten-2020>
- Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. "FINAL REPORT: RESEARCH ON INTERNATIONAL EXCHANGE HOST FAMILY 2019 AND 2020." 2024. <https://www.state.gov/documents/attachment/1047/2024-04-10-afsc-final-report.pdf>
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. "Products - Data Briefs - Number 641 - August 2022." *Centers for Disease Control and Prevention*, no. 641. 8 Aug. 2022. <https://www.cdc.gov/data/briefs/641/data-brief-641-2022.html>
- David Cox. "Growing Trends and Enduring Patterns in American Family Life." *AFS Survey Center on American Life*, February 8, 2023. <https://www.afscenter.org/en-us/center-on-american-life/research-trends-and-enduring-patterns-in-american-family-life/>
- Cox, David A. "The Lonely Childhood of Generation Z." *Survey Center on American Life*, February 15, 2023. <https://www.afscenter.org/en-us/center-on-american-life/research-trends-and-enduring-patterns-in-american-family-life/>
- Only Images. 2023. Unlabeled. Accessed March 15, 2023. <https://www.onlyimages.com/search/Generations>
- Smithsonian Family Hall Foundation. 2024. "US again record number of student visas in 2023." *The Pie*. <https://thepie.com/us-again-record-number-of-student-visas-in-2023/>
- New Research Center. "1. The American Family Today." *New Research Center's Social & Demographic Trends Project*, December 17, 2019. <https://www.newresearchcenter.org/research/2019/12/17/1-the-american-family-today>
- Wojcik, Tracy. "How GDP Shatters 30-Year Low: Recovery Momentum Continues." *Crucial 33*, Louis Inc., 8 Dec. 2024. <https://www.gdp33.com/news/2024/12/08/gdp-recovery-momentum-continues/>

Bibliography

- Bundyra, Katie. 2025. "The Value of a Handwritten Note." Primerus.
<https://www.primerus.com/article/value-handwritten-note>.
- Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs, "FINAL REPORT: RESEARCH on INTERNATIONAL EXCHANGE HOST FAMILIES and SCHOOLS," 2024,
https://eca.state.gov/files/bureau/eca_mel_host_families_report_final_508_compliant.pdf
- Black, Lindsey. "Organized Sports Participation among Children Aged 6–17 Years: United States, 2020." August 11, 2022. <https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/products/databriefs/db441.htm>.
- Cox, Daniel A. "The Lonely Childhood of Generation Z." *Survey Center on American Life*, February 15, 2023. <https://www.americansurveycenter.org/the-lonely-childhood-of-generation-z/>.
- Explore St. Louis. 14 Feb. 2025. "Things to Do in St Louis With Teens: Teen Activities in STL." explorestlouis.com/guide/traveling-teenagers.
- Getty Images. 2025. *iStock*. Accessed March 30, 2025.
<https://www.istockphoto.com/search/2/image-film?phrase=family+of+four+teens>
- Nash, Polly. 2024. "US rejects record number of student visas in 2023." *The Pie*.
<https://thepienews.com/us-rejects-record-number-of-student-visas-in-2023/>.
- Norman, Dennis. 2024. "St. Louis MSA's Population Dynamics Over 50 Years." *St. Louis Real Estate News*. St. Louis MSA's Population Dynamics Over 50 Years.
- Pew Research Center. "1. The American Family Today." Pew Research Center's Social & Demographic Trends Project, December 17, 2015. <https://www.pewresearch.org/social-trends/2015/12/17/1-the-american-family-today>
- Pignataro, Jessica. "Host Family Survey Results" *HostFamilies.org*, May 3, 2016.
<https://hostfamilies.org/host-family-survey-results/>.
- StudyTravel Network. "CSIET Survey Finds Host Family Recruitment Challenges for US Programmes." *StudyTravel Magazine*, July 26, 2023.
<https://studytravel.network/magazine/news/2/31214>.
- Tanzako, Abisola. "Why Voice SMS Can Be More Effective Than Text Messages." *arkesel.com*, 29 Oct. 2024, arkesel.com/why-voice-sms-can-be-more-effective-than-text-messages/#:~:text=A%20study%20by%20Stanford%20University,keep%20that%20emotional%20bond%20strong.
- Wyche, Tony. "New GDP Numbers Show St. Louis' Economic Momentum Continues." *Greater St. Louis Inc.*, 6 Dec. 2024, [greaterstlinc.com/news/press-release/new-gdp-numbers-show-st-louis-economic-momentum-continues#:~:text=for%20the%20future.",ST.,region's%20population%20ranking%20of%2023](https://greaterstlinc.com/news/press-release/new-gdp-numbers-show-st-louis-economic-momentum-continues#:~:text=for%20the%20future.).